CHIBASE CONSULTING / TRUSTLEDGER SRM

SOCIAL ENGAGEMENT & PARTICIPATION (SEP) MODULE

REFERENCE FRAMEWORK FOR PARTICIPATORY SOCIAL ENGAGEMENT METHODOLOGIES

Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA)
Participatory Learning and Action (PLA)
Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR)

Version: 1.0
Purpose: Methodological reference for development of tender-grade Social Engagement Plans (SEPs), stakeholder engagement strategies, community participation programmes and participatory monitoring within the TrustLedger SRM.

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1. PURPOSE OF THIS REFERENCE DOCUMENT

This document establishes a methodological reference framework for incorporating Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA), Participatory Learning and Action (PLA), and Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR) into the TrustLedger Social Engagement & Participation (SEP) module.

The purpose is not to prescribe a single methodology for every project.

Instead, the framework enables the SEP module to determine:

1. what the social and participation problem is;
2. who needs to participate;
3. what type of knowledge must be generated;
4. which participatory methods are appropriate;
5. how participation will influence project decisions;
6. how evidence generated through participation will be recorded;
7. how community feedback will be incorporated;
8. how participation and social outcomes will be monitored; and
9. how the resulting process can be demonstrated as auditable evidence in a tender, project, compliance or reporting environment.

The fundamental principle is:

> **Participation should not merely produce attendance; it should produce knowledge, influence, decisions, action and evidence.**

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2. WHY PRA, PLA AND CBPR MATTER TO THE SRM

Traditional stakeholder engagement frequently treats communities primarily as recipients of information.

A mature Social Engagement Plan requires a different approach.

Communities may possess important knowledge concerning:

- local history;
- settlement patterns;
- social relationships;
- informal leadership;
- service access;
- livelihood systems;
- community risks;
- local infrastructure;
- social vulnerabilities;
- cultural practices;
- perceptions of development;
- previous project experiences;
- institutional relationships; and
- potential sources of conflict or cooperation.

Participatory methodologies provide structured mechanisms through which this knowledge can be identified, analysed and incorporated into project decision-making.

PRA developed as an approach through which local people could share, analyse and enhance their own knowledge and use it for planning and action. Its methodological family includes mapping, transect walks, ranking, seasonal calendars, trend analysis, diagrams and other visual and analytical tools.

PLA subsequently broadened the emphasis toward continuing cycles of participation, learning and action. Robert Chambers describes PRA/PLA as families of approaches involving behaviours and attitudes, methods and practices of sharing, with applications including planning, empowerment, rights, security, natural-resource management and community-level action.

CBPR adds a research-partnership dimension. It emphasises collaborative inquiry around community-identified issues, equitable partnerships, co-learning, capacity development and the application of knowledge to practice and policy.

For TrustLedger, this creates an opportunity to move from:

Stakeholder Engagement

to:

Participatory Social Intelligence

to:

Evidence-Based Social Risk and Impact Management.

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3. THE THREE METHODOLOGIES

3.1 Participatory Rural Appraisal — PRA

Definition

PRA is a family of participatory approaches and methods designed to enable local people to share, analyse and enhance their knowledge of their circumstances, and to use that knowledge for planning and action.

Although the term contains the word "rural", PRA techniques are not restricted to rural environments. They have been adapted to urban development, infrastructure, health, education, natural-resource management, poverty programmes and community planning.

FAO resources identify PRA tools including maps, transects, seasonal calendars, time trends, Venn diagrams, priority matrices and ranking techniques.

Core philosophy

PRA shifts the role of the external practitioner:

FROM

"We collect information from the community."

TO

"We facilitate communities to analyse and communicate their own knowledge."

The quality of PRA therefore depends not simply on the tools used but on facilitator behaviour, power relationships, inclusion and the extent to which participants own the analysis.

Primary PRA applications in the SRM

PRA is particularly appropriate for:

- community profiling;
- baseline assessments;
- social mapping;
- infrastructure and service mapping;
- stakeholder identification;

- vulnerability assessment;
- community needs assessment;
- livelihood assessment;
- historical analysis;
- social-risk identification;
- community prioritisation;
- land-use understanding;
- resource-access analysis;
- conflict identification;
- project-impact assessment.

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4. CORE PRA TOOLS FOR THE SEP MODULE

4.1 Participatory Mapping

Participants create maps representing features that are important to them.

Possible mapping themes include:

- households;
- infrastructure;
- roads;
- schools;
- clinics;
- water points;
- public facilities;
- economic activity;
- unsafe areas;
- environmental resources;
- cultural sites;
- social institutions;
- vulnerable households;
- areas affected by projects.

FAO notes that different stakeholder groups may produce substantially different maps of the same area. This makes mapping particularly useful for identifying different perceptions, priorities and potential conflicts.

SRM application

The SEP module should be able to record:

Map Type → Geographic Area → Participant Group → Issues Identified → Evidence → GIS Location → Risk/Opportunity → Action Required.

This can eventually connect directly to the SRM Geographic Area and Stakeholder structures.

4.2 Transect Walk

A transect walk is a structured walk through an area with community members or key informants.

The purpose is to observe, discuss and verify conditions on the ground.

Transects can identify:

- infrastructure conditions;
- environmental problems;
- settlement patterns;
- access routes;
- land-use conflicts;
- service gaps;
- safety issues;
- livelihood activities;
- informal economic activity;
- areas of vulnerability.

FAO describes transects as particularly useful for verifying and refining information generated through mapping.

SRM application

The system should record:

- date;
- location;
- participants;
- route;
- observations;
- photographs;
- identified issues;
- responsible stakeholder;
- risk classification;
- action;
- status;
- verification date.

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5. SEASONAL CALENDAR

A seasonal calendar examines how activities, risks, needs and vulnerabilities change throughout the year.

Variables can include:

- employment;
- income;
- migration;
- household expenditure;
- water availability;
- food security;
- school attendance;
- illness;
- community events;
- agricultural activities;
- construction activity;
- household workload;
- conflict periods;
- community meetings.

FAO identifies seasonal calendars as useful for identifying periods of stress, vulnerability, labour availability and appropriate timing for interventions.

SRM application

A seasonal calendar can become a **Social Risk Forecasting tool**.

For example:

Period	Risk	Affected Group	Severity	Trigger	Mitigation
January	School transport pressure	Youth/parents	Medium	School opening	Engagement
December	Reduced availability	Community leaders	Medium	Festive period	Reschedule
Winter	Water constraints	Households	High	Low supply	Escalation

This creates a direct link between participatory engagement and SRM early-warning functionality.

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6. SOCIAL AND INSTITUTIONAL MAPPING

Social mapping identifies people, groups, institutions and relationships.

Potential stakeholders include:

- traditional councils;
- ward councillors;

- municipal officials;
- community leaders;
- religious organisations;
- schools;
- clinics;
- NGOs;
- CBOs;
- youth organisations;
- women's organisations;
- businesses;
- informal traders;
- contractors;
- labour organisations;
- vulnerable groups.

Venn and linkage diagrams can be used to explore institutional relationships and perceived importance or influence.

SRM application

This can feed directly into:

Stakeholder Register → Influence → Interest → Relationship → Sentiment → Risk → Engagement Strategy.

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7. WEALTH / WELL-BEING RANKING

Wealth or well-being ranking uses community-defined criteria to classify relative socio-economic conditions.

Importantly, the objective is not necessarily to impose an external definition of poverty.

The community can identify locally meaningful characteristics of:

- vulnerability;
- well-being;
- household stability;
- economic security;
- access to services;
- livelihood security.

FAO describes wealth ranking as a card-sorting exercise that elicits community-defined criteria of socio-economic status and relative household well-being.

SRM application

Potential uses include:

- vulnerability profiling;
- beneficiary prioritisation;
- social-impact baselines;
- livelihood assessments;
- targeting of community interventions.

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8. RANKING AND PRIORITISATION

Participatory ranking enables participants to compare problems, needs, opportunities or proposed solutions.

Methods include:

- pairwise ranking;
- matrix ranking;
- scoring;
- priority matrices;
- options assessment.

Examples:

Problem: Water shortages

Participants may rank:

1. Reliability
2. Distance
3. Quality
4. Cost
5. Maintenance

The important principle is that the criteria should be transparent and the basis of the ranking documented.

SRM application

The system should preserve:

- issue;
- participant group;
- criteria;
- score;

- ranking;
- rationale;
- minority views;
- resulting decision.

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9. TIME LINES AND HISTORICAL PROFILES

Historical timelines allow communities to reconstruct significant events and changes.

Potential themes:

- previous development projects;
- infrastructure failures;
- political changes;
- migration;
- community conflicts;
- service improvements;
- disasters;
- previous stakeholder disputes;
- major economic changes.

Historical analysis can reveal why current stakeholder attitudes exist.

This is particularly important where communities have experienced repeated projects that failed to deliver promised benefits.

SRM application

A timeline can contribute to:

Stakeholder Sentiment History

and

Community Trust History.

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10. PROBLEM TREE ANALYSIS

Problem-tree analysis separates:

Root causes → Core problem → Consequences

Example:

ROOT CAUSES

- poor communication
- inadequate consultation
- unclear procurement information
- unemployment

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CORE PROBLEM Community opposition to project

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CONSEQUENCES

- protests
- access restrictions
- project delays
- reputational damage

This is highly suitable for the SRM because it moves engagement beyond recording complaints toward understanding underlying causes.

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11. PARTICIPATORY LEARNING AND ACTION — PLA

11.1 Definition

PLA evolved from participatory approaches including PRA.

The emphasis is not merely on assessing a community but on creating a process in which participants:

Learn → Analyse → Reflect → Plan → Act → Review → Learn again.

Chambers describes PRA/PLA as methodologies combining participatory behaviours, methods and practices of sharing, with an emphasis on enabling people to express and enhance their knowledge and take action.

PLA therefore introduces an important principle for TrustLedger:

> **Participation is a continuing process rather than a once-off consultation event.**

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12. PLA AS A CYCLE

The SEP module should conceptualise PLA as:

1. LISTEN

Capture community knowledge, concerns and perceptions.

2. ANALYSE

Facilitate collective examination of issues.

3. PRIORITISE

Identify what matters most.

4. PLAN

Develop practical responses.

5. ACT

Implement agreed actions.

6. MONITOR

Track progress and emerging issues.

7. REFLECT

Return to stakeholders and evaluate what happened.

8. ADAPT

Modify the intervention based on learning.

Then the cycle begins again.

This makes PLA particularly suitable for projects requiring ongoing stakeholder engagement, adaptive management and social-risk monitoring.

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13. PLA AND THE SRM

PLA can provide the methodological foundation for the SRM's:

- engagement cycles;
- issue tracking;
- action registers;
- community feedback;
- participatory monitoring;
- grievance learning;
- social-risk reviews;
- project adaptation;
- stakeholder validation.

The SRM should therefore avoid treating an SEP as a static document.

Instead:

SEP = Living Social Management Framework

with continuous updates generated through participation.

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14. COMMUNITY-BASED PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH — CBPR

14.1 Definition

CBPR is more than a collection of community-engagement tools.

It is a collaborative research approach in which community members, organisations and researchers participate in the research process.

The literature distinguishes CBPR from research that merely occurs "in" a community. CBPR involves active community participation in the research process and seeks equitable participation and shared control.

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15. CORE CBPR PRINCIPLES

The foundational literature identifies principles including:

1. Recognising the community as a unit of identity.

2. Building on community strengths and resources.
3. Facilitating collaborative partnerships in all phases of research.
4. Integrating knowledge and action for mutual benefit.
5. Promoting co-learning and capacity building.
6. Addressing inequalities in power and resource sharing.
7. Using an iterative and cyclical process.
8. Disseminating findings to all partners.

These principles are consistent with later public-health and community-engagement literature emphasising equitable partnership, co-learning, mutual benefit and long-term commitment.

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16. CBPR IS PARTICULARLY IMPORTANT FOR THE SRM

CBPR can strengthen the SRM where the project requires:

- social baseline research;
- impact assessments;
- community perception studies;
- longitudinal monitoring;
- community-generated indicators;
- participatory evaluation;
- social research;
- policy research;
- vulnerable-group research;
- community health or livelihood assessments;
- evidence-based programme design.

CBPR also provides a framework for ensuring that communities are not simply sources of information.

They become **partners in generating, interpreting and applying knowledge.**

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17. PRA VS PLA VS CBPR

Dimension	PRA	PLA	CBPR
Primary emphasis	Participatory appraisal	Learning and action	Collaborative research
Typical orientation	Understand and analyse	Learn, plan, act and adapt	Research, action and change

Dimension	PRA	PLA	CBPR
Community role	Knowledge holder and analyst	Participant, learner and actor	Research partner
External practitioner	Facilitator	Facilitator/learning partner	Research partner
Time orientation	Often focused exercise/ process	Iterative and continuing	Often longer-term
Main outputs	Maps, rankings, calendars, analysis	Plans, actions, learning	Research evidence, findings, action
Power emphasis	Reduce outsider dominance	Empower participation and action	Explicitly address power and equity
Best SRM application	Baseline/social intelligence	Engagement/action cycles	Participatory research and impact assessment

18. THE RECOMMENDED TRUSTLEDGER MODEL

The SRM should not force users to choose only one.

Instead:

PRA = DISCOVER

Use PRA to understand the social environment.

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PLA = ENGAGE & ACT

Use PLA to facilitate learning, planning, action and adaptation.

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CBPR = GENERATE EVIDENCE

Use CBPR where formal participatory research is required.

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TRUSTLEDGER = RECORD, ANALYSE, MONITOR & REPORT

The SRM becomes the digital system connecting the three.

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19. PROPOSED SEP METHODOLOGICAL ARCHITECTURE

LEVEL 1 — SOCIAL CONTEXT

Capture:

- geographic context;
- demographic characteristics;
- institutions;
- community history;
- socio-economic conditions;
- infrastructure;
- stakeholder environment.

LEVEL 2 — PARTICIPATORY DIAGNOSIS

Use PRA techniques:

- mapping;
- transects;
- calendars;
- rankings;
- Venn diagrams;
- historical timelines;
- problem trees.

LEVEL 3 — PARTICIPATORY PLANNING

Use PLA:

- prioritisation;
- action planning;
- community validation;
- implementation;
- monitoring;
- reflection.

LEVEL 4 — PARTICIPATORY RESEARCH

Use CBPR:

- research questions;
- community research partners;
- data collection;
- interpretation;
- validation;
- knowledge sharing;
- action.

LEVEL 5 — DIGITAL SOCIAL INTELLIGENCE

TrustLedger records:

- participants;
- issues;
- evidence;
- decisions;
- commitments;
- risks;
- grievances;
- actions;
- outcomes;
- stakeholder sentiment;
- participation history.

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20. TENDER-GRADE SEP APPLICATION

A tender-grade SEP should demonstrate much more than:

"Community meetings will be held."

Instead, it should demonstrate:

A. PURPOSE

Why participation is required.

B. STAKEHOLDER ANALYSIS

Who must participate and why.

C. PARTICIPATORY METHODOLOGY

Which methods will be used.

D. INCLUSION STRATEGY

How marginalised and less-visible groups will participate.

E. DATA STRATEGY

How information will be collected, validated, stored and analysed.

F. DECISION LINKAGE

How community inputs will influence project decisions.

G. SOCIAL-RISK MANAGEMENT

How emerging risks will be identified and escalated.

H. GRIEVANCE INTEGRATION

How grievances will feed into learning and corrective action.

I. FEEDBACK

How findings and decisions will be returned to participants.

J. MONITORING

How participation effectiveness will be measured.

K. EVIDENCE

How participation will be demonstrated through auditable records.

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21. PARTICIPATORY METHOD SELECTION MATRIX

SEP Requirement	Recommended Method
Community profile	PRA
Social mapping	PRA
Infrastructure mapping	PRA

SEP Requirement	Recommended Method
Stakeholder mapping	PRA + PLA
Community history	PRA
Seasonal vulnerability	PRA
Community priorities	PRA
Problem analysis	PRA + PLA
Community action planning	PLA
Participatory monitoring	PLA
Adaptive engagement	PLA
Formal community research	CBPR
Impact research	CBPR
Community-defined indicators	CBPR
Participatory evaluation	CBPR
Knowledge co-production	CBPR
Long-term partnership	CBPR + PLA
Social-risk intelligence	PRA + PLA + SRM
Grievance learning	PLA + CBPR
Community validation	PLA + CBPR

22. INCLUSION AND REPRESENTATION

One of the most important methodological safeguards is that "the community" must not be treated as a homogeneous group.

FAO specifically warns that communities are rarely homogeneous and that those absent from participatory processes may include the poorest and most disadvantaged.

The SEP should therefore identify:

- women;
- men;
- youth;
- older persons;
- persons with disabilities;

- informal workers;
- unemployed residents;
- tenants;
- land users;
- traditional leadership structures;
- formal political structures;
- vulnerable households;
- minority groups;
- local businesses;
- civil society;
- affected households.

The SRM should record **who participated and who did not**, rather than simply recording that "community consultation took place."

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23. TRIANGULATION

Participatory information should not automatically be treated as verified fact.

PRA literature places considerable emphasis on triangulation: using different methods, sources, disciplines, informants and locations to cross-check findings.

The SRM should therefore distinguish between:

Community perception

Observed condition

Documentary evidence

Administrative data

Technical assessment

Verified finding

This is a major opportunity for TrustLedger.

It allows the system to preserve the difference between:

> "The community says..."

and

> "The evidence demonstrates..."

without dismissing either.

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24. PARTICIPATORY EVIDENCE MODEL

Every participatory engagement should ideally produce structured evidence.

Engagement Record

Who participated?

Where?

When?

Why?

Which method?

What was discussed?

What was discovered?

What was agreed?

What remains contested?

What action is required?

Who is responsible?

By when?

What evidence supports completion?

This turns participation into an auditable management process.

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25. PARTICIPATION QUALITY INDICATORS

The SRM SEP module should eventually measure more than the number of meetings.

Suggested indicators include:

Participation

- number of engagements;
- attendance;
- stakeholder coverage;
- demographic representation;
- repeat participation.

Inclusion

- women represented;
- youth represented;
- vulnerable groups represented;
- marginalised groups represented;
- accessibility measures implemented.

Quality

- issues raised;
- issues acknowledged;
- issues investigated;
- community recommendations accepted;
- community recommendations rejected with reasons.

Influence

- decisions influenced;
- project changes resulting from participation;
- mitigation measures generated;
- stakeholder commitments fulfilled.

Trust

- stakeholder sentiment;
- unresolved concerns;
- recurring grievances;
- response time;
- perception of transparency.

Outcomes

- issues resolved;
- risks reduced;
- commitments completed;
- community capacity increased;
- social outcomes achieved.

26. ETHICS AND DATA GOVERNANCE

Participatory research must protect participants.

Depending on the project, the SEP should address:

- informed participation;
- confidentiality;
- consent;
- protection of personal information;
- sensitive information;
- vulnerable participants;
- data ownership;
- research permissions;
- secure data storage;
- appropriate publication;
- feedback to participants.

CBPR literature also emphasises reciprocal benefit, trust, community knowledge and appropriate community participation throughout the research process.

For South African implementation, the SRM SEP should incorporate applicable requirements relating to POPIA, research ethics, client contractual requirements and sector-specific regulatory obligations.

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27. ROLE OF THE SOCIAL FACILITATOR

The facilitator should not become the "voice of the community."

The facilitator's role is to:

- create an appropriate participation environment;
- ensure diverse voices are heard;
- manage power imbalances;
- encourage evidence-based discussion;
- facilitate analysis;
- document outcomes;
- clarify disagreements;
- support community learning;
- connect participation to decision-making;
- ensure feedback.

PRA's emphasis on facilitation is particularly relevant: the external practitioner should enable people to conduct more of the investigation and analysis themselves rather than simply extracting information from them.

28. TENDER-GRADE METHODOLOGY STATEMENT

A high-quality SEP methodology can therefore state:

> The project will adopt an integrated participatory methodology combining Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA), Participatory Learning and Action (PLA), and, where research objectives require, Community-Based Participatory Research (CBPR). PRA techniques will be used to establish a grounded understanding of the social, spatial, institutional and socio-economic context. PLA processes will support continuous stakeholder learning, prioritisation, action planning, monitoring and adaptive management. CBPR principles will be applied to formal participatory research components to promote equitable partnerships, co-learning, community participation in knowledge generation and the translation of findings into practical action.

This formulation is substantially stronger than simply stating that "community consultations will be conducted."

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29. SRM DATA MODEL IMPLICATIONS

The methodology suggests that the SEP module should eventually contain structured entities for:

Participatory Engagement

- Engagement ID
- Project
- Geographic Area
- Date
- Method
- Purpose
- Facilitator
- Stakeholder Groups
- Participants
- Issues
- Findings
- Decisions
- Actions

Participatory Tool

- Tool type
- Objective
- Participant group
- Facilitator

• Evidence
• Findings
• Validation status

Participatory Finding

• Finding
• Source
• Method
• Participant group
• Confidence
• Verification status
• Related risk
• Related stakeholder
• Related geographic area

Community Action

• Action
• Responsible party
• Target date
• Status
• Evidence
• Verification

Participation Indicator

• Indicator
• Baseline
• Target
• Actual
• Evidence
• Trend

This architecture would allow SEP information to become part of the wider TrustLedger social-risk and impact intelligence system.

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30. PROPOSED SRM PARTICIPATORY INTELLIGENCE CHAIN

The complete process can be represented as:

PARTICIPATE

↓

GENERATE LOCAL KNOWLEDGE

↓

ANALYSE

↓

VALIDATE

↓

IDENTIFY SOCIAL RISKS / OPPORTUNITIES

↓

PRIORITISE

↓

MAKE DECISIONS

↓

ASSIGN ACTION

↓

MONITOR

↓

VERIFY

↓

LEARN

↓

ADAPT

↓

REPORT

This is the point at which the SEP module becomes more than an engagement register.

It becomes a **Social Management System**.

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31. IMPORTANT DISTINCTION FOR TRUSTLEDGER

The SRM should never claim that using PRA, PLA or CBPR automatically makes an engagement process participatory.

The **quality of participation** matters.

A workshop can use a participatory tool while still being:

- dominated by officials;
- controlled by elites;
- inaccessible to vulnerable groups;
- designed without community influence;
- disconnected from decisions.

Therefore, TrustLedger should evaluate both:

METHOD USED

and

QUALITY OF PARTICIPATION.

This distinction is critical for producing credible tender-grade SEPs.

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32. RECOMMENDED SEP QUALITY TEST

Before an SEP is submitted, the SRM should test whether it answers:

1. Who participates?
2. Why do they participate?
3. What knowledge do they contribute?
4. Which participatory method is appropriate?
5. How will marginalised voices be included?
6. How will information be verified?
7. How will disagreements be recorded?
8. How will community inputs influence decisions?
9. How will actions be assigned?

10. How will grievances feed into learning?
11. How will participation be monitored?
12. How will outcomes be verified?
13. How will feedback return to stakeholders?
14. How will the process be documented?
15. How will the evidence support contractual reporting?

If the SEP cannot answer these questions, it should not yet be considered tender-grade.

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33. STRATEGIC CONCLUSION

PRA, PLA and CBPR should become part of the **methodological intelligence layer** of TrustLedger's SEP module.

They should not simply appear as selectable methodologies in a dropdown.

The system should be able to determine:

Project context → participation objective → stakeholder group → participation method → evidence → finding → risk/opportunity → decision → action → outcome.

This creates a much stronger proposition:

> **TrustLedger does not merely document stakeholder engagement. It structures, manages, evidences and learns from participation.**

That distinction could become one of the defining characteristics of the SEP module.

REFERENCE BASE

1. Chambers, R. — work on Participatory Rural Appraisal and Participatory Learning and Action. IDS identifies PRA/PLA as families of participatory methodologies that evolved through practices of sharing, learning, empowerment and action.

2. Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) — participatory appraisal resources covering mapping, transects, seasonal calendars, ranking, Venn diagrams, historical analysis and triangulation.

3. Israel, B.A., Schulz, A.J., Parker, E.A. & Becker, A.B. (1998), *Review of Community-Based Research: Assessing Partnership Approaches to Improve Public Health*, Annual Review of Public Health.

4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention — literature describing CBPR as collaborative inquiry based on community-identified issues, equitable partnerships, participation, co-learning and application to practice and policy.

5. CDC — literature on community advisory boards and participatory partnerships, including representation of community members in research activities.

6. NCBI — community-based participatory research and evaluation principles, including equitable participation and shared control across the research process.